

A Neighbor in Need.

It was Friday afternoon, and seventeen-year-old Ethan was standing by his locker, completely stressed out. The bell had just rung, and he had exactly one hour to finish his art project before the deadline. If he didn't hand it in, he would fail the class and get kicked off the basketball team.

Ethan was tired of feeling like the world was against him. He worked hard, but his grades were slipping, and he felt helpless.

As he slammed his locker shut, he noticed Maya sitting on the floor in the hallway. Her backpack was on the floor, and papers, flashcards, and books were scattered everywhere. She was frantically trying to clean them up, tears streaming down her face.

She was a quiet girl in Ethan's grade. She didn't have many friends, and kids usually just ignored her.

Ethan stepped over a stray book, keeping his eyes on his watch. "Thirty minutes left," he thought. "I don't have time for this. Someone else will help her."

Just then, Mr. Davis, the history teacher, walked out of his classroom. He saw Maya crying, and then he looked right at Ethan, who was trying to walk away.

"Ethan," Mr. Davis called out softly. "Hold up a second."

Ethan sighed stopped in his tracks. "Mr. Davis, I really have to go to the art room. If I don't finish my project in thirty minutes, I'm off the team."

Mr. Davis looked at Ethan with kind but serious eyes. "Ethan, do you remember the story of the Good Samaritan we talked about in culture class last week?"

Ethan groaned inwardly. "Yeah. A guy gets jumped by thieves, and the religious leaders walk right past him because they're too busy or don't want to get dirty. Then a Samaritan stops and helps him."

Mr. Davis nodded. "Exactly. The people who walked past had really important jobs to do. They had places to be. But Jesus said that story to show us that our 'neighbor' isn't just our best friend or someone who can do us

a favor. Our neighbor is anyone who is hurting right in front of us when we have the power to help them. Maya's family is going through a really hard time right now, and she's drowning in stress."

Mr. Davis placed a hand on Ethan's shoulder. "We don't just show kindness when it's easy or convenient, Ethan. We show it because it's what we're called to do. Maya is your neighbor right now."

The words hit Ethan like a punch to the stomach. He looked back at Maya, who was still on the floor, looking completely overwhelmed. Ethan realized his own bad attitude had made him look selfish and stupid. He was acting just like the people who walked right past the hurt guy on the road, prioritizing his own goals over a person in deep pain.

"Okay," Ethan muttered.

He walked out into the hallway and dropped to his knees next to Maya. "Hey," he said gently. "Let me help."

Maya looked up, surprised. "You don't have to do that, Ethan. Don't you have your art project?"

"It can wait," Ethan said, giving her a small smile.

For the next ten minutes, Ethan didn't just help her pack up her bag. He helped her organize all her messy flashcards, and listened to her vent about how scared she was about failing her exams.

By the time Ethan finally made it to the art room, there were only twenty minutes left before the teacher, Ms. Carter, locked the door. Ethan worked like crazy, his hands flying across the canvas. He didn't finish it perfectly, but he got it done and handed it in right as the clock struck 4:00 PM.

As he walked out of the school into the afternoon sun, Ethan's arms ached and he was exhausted. He didn't even know if he'd get an A on the project. But as he looked back at the school gates, he felt a weird, deep sense of peace that he hadn't felt in a long time. The stress he had been carrying all week was gone. He had finally understood what it actually meant to care for his neighbor.

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Short Story Writing (OPEN)

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